The Kingdom of God

Mark 1–2; Matthew 5–7; 13

The big idea: Jesus announced that the kingdom of God had arrived, and he showed it by calling fishermen, touching a leper, and eating with sinners. His kingdom turns the world upside down, belongs to the poor in spirit, and demands a righteousness only he can give. It is already here and not yet complete, a treasure worth everything.

Before you meet: Read

Mark 1:14–20, 40–45; 2:13–17 | Matthew 5:1–20 | Matthew 5:21–48 | Matthew 6:9–13, 19–34 | Matthew 13:31–33, 44–46

Open (5 minutes)

If you could change one thing about how the world works, what would it be?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; _____ and believe in the gospel." *(Mark 1:15)*

"Those who are well have no need of a _____, but those who are sick." *(Mark 2:17)*

"Blessed are the _____ in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." *(Matthew 5:3)*

"Unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and _____, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven." *(Matthew 5:20)*

"Your kingdom come, your _____ be done, on earth as it is in heaven." *(Matthew 6:10)*

"Then in his _____ he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field." *(Matthew 13:44)*

Discuss

1. Jesus touched a leper and ate with sinners. Who are the people everyone avoids in your world? What would it look like to move toward them? *Mark 1:40–42; 2:15–17*

2. Read the Beatitudes. Which one surprises you most? Which one do you most need? *Matthew 5:3–10*

3. Jesus said anger and lust break God's law in the heart. How does the Sermon on the Mount work as a mirror for you? *Matthew 5:21–30, 48*

4. If no one can reach the righteousness Jesus requires, how does anyone enter the kingdom? *Matthew 5:20; Philippians 3:9; John 3:3*

5. The kingdom is already here and not yet complete. Where do you see it already? Where are you still longing for it? *Matthew 13:31–33; 6:10; Colossians 1:13*

6. In Jesus' parables a man sells everything in his joy. What would it look like for you to treat the kingdom as treasure? *Matthew 13:44–46*

Apply this week

Read Matthew 5–7 this week. Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly each day, and when you pray your kingdom come, name one heart, starting with your own, where you long to see Jesus obeyed as King. Then move toward one person others avoid.

Memory verse

"But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you."

Matthew 6:33

Pray

Come to God poor in spirit, with nothing to offer but your need. Thank Jesus for the righteousness he gives and the price he paid. Pray, Your kingdom come, your will be done, in your heart, your home, and your church.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 20

The Kingdom of God

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Mark 1:14–20, 40–42 aloud together. Then read Matthew 5:1–12.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Upside-Down Kingdom table and the Already and Not Yet diagram in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 21 (Mark 14–15; Isaiah 52:13–53:12).

Main points to land

1. Jesus' first message was the kingdom of God: God's saving rule arriving in his Son (Mark 1:15; Colossians 1:13).
2. Jesus showed the kingdom by calling ordinary people, healing, and welcoming outcasts and sinners (Mark 1:17, 41; 2:17).
3. The kingdom is upside down. It belongs to the poor in spirit, and greatness means serving (Matthew 5:3–10; Mark 10:43–45).
4. The Sermon on the Mount first shows that no one reaches God's righteousness, then guides those who receive Christ's righteousness by faith (Matthew 5:20, 48; Philippians 3:9).
5. The kingdom is already here and not yet complete. We enter by new birth, repentance, and faith, and we pray, Your kingdom come (John 3:3; Matthew 6:10).

Core doctrine to teach

The Holy Spirit and the New Birth CORE DOCTRINE 20 OF 26

No one can enter God's kingdom by trying harder. We must be born again. The Holy Spirit gives new life to spiritually dead hearts, opens our eyes to see Christ, and makes us willing to trust him. Faith itself is his gift. *John 3:3–8; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Titus 3:5; Ephesians 2:4–5, 8*

Answer key (Observe)

1. repent
2. physician
3. poor
4. Pharisees
5. will

6. joy

Questions people will ask

Is the kingdom of God a political program?
No. The kingdom is God's saving rule through his Son. Jesus said his kingdom is not of this world (John 18:36). It changes how citizens live in every area of life, including how they treat the poor and their neighbors, but it advances through the gospel and new hearts, not through a party or a nation.

Do we have to keep the Sermon on the Mount to be saved?
No one can keep it perfectly, and that is the first lesson it teaches (Matthew 5:48). We are saved by faith in Christ, whose perfect obedience and death are credited to us (Philippians 3:9). Then the Sermon becomes a portrait of the new life the Spirit grows in those who belong to Jesus.

Did Jesus really mean turn the other cheek and love your enemies?
Yes, for his followers' personal conduct (Matthew 5:39, 44). Jesus is forbidding personal revenge, not the work of governments to restrain evil (Romans 13:4). It is hard, and it is only possible because God first loved us while we were his enemies (Romans 5:10).

If the kingdom has come, why is the world still so broken?
The kingdom has begun but is not yet complete. Like a mustard seed, it starts small and grows (Matthew 13:31–32). Jesus will return to finish what he started, and until then we pray, Your kingdom come (Matthew 6:10; Revelation 11:15).

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that your kingdom has come in Jesus. We come poor in spirit, with nothing to bring but our need. Thank you for the righteousness your Son gives and the price he paid. Make us citizens who serve, forgive, and move toward the outcast. Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Amen.